between the two countries, there is a degree of alignment in their positions when it comes to their respective issues in conflict with China. But this degree of convergence is not enough for the formation of an explicit alliance.

Military dependence, the other determinant of alliance decisions, is a function of four factors: 1) intensity of the threat, 2) need for military assistance from ally to tackle the threat, 3) ally's capacity to provide military assistance, and 4) the availability of alternative allies. There is wide agreement among analysts that the threat posed by China to India's security and interests is likely to increase in the years to come as China's power grows, its ambitions expand, and its ability to project power beyond its borders increases. As the authors of Nonalignment 2.0 noted, China constitutes "the single most important challenge for Indian strategy" because of its increasing ability to directly impinge upon India's "geo-political space" in Asia.[115] Would India need military assistance from America to cope with the China threat? In terms of sheer numbers, the military balance is indeed in China's favour. China's development of infrastructure in Tibet has considerably enhanced its ability to mobilise a greater number of forces in a faster timeframe. However, China's continued preoccupation with security challenges along its eastern seaboard and the constraints imposed by terrain, weather, and distance in projecting power through and from Tibet limit the scope and intensity of the military challenge that it can generate against India. That means India is unlikely to need direct military assistance from America or any other potential ally during a limited India–China war. What India might need instead are diplomatic support including at the UN Security Council, continued supply of weapons and spares, intelligence about the adversary's military dispositions, and so on.

While diplomatic and limited material support might suffice in the context of an India–China border conflict,